continued to add fuel to the fire in Punjab, to keep the Indian security forces tied up with restoring peace and stability in the state. On the other hand, the ISI upgraded the level of its covert support to separatists in Jammu and Kashmir and increased the level of cross-border infiltration of Pakistan-based terrorists.

The overstretched Indian security forces were thereafter forced to control the situation on two fronts. While Punjab was still counting its dead and looking for missing loved ones, by the time the situation stabilized in in that state, it had worsened considerably in J&K. I have always believed, and have shared my views on the subject with close friends, that the situation in J&K would not have worsened as it has, had 1 Akbar Road not fiddled with the situation in Punjab.

The outcome of Op-2 launched by the 1 Akbar Road group in the early 1980s ended in the events of 1984. It also gave birth to a hitherto non-existent issue – Khalistan – thereby providing an opportunity to certain countries, particularly Pakistan, to use that as a handle to further their respective agendas vis-a-vis India. The ISI would find one reason or another to continue destabilizing the strategically located state of Punjab. A new dimension to this situation was added when, in August 2019, the NDA government revoked Article 370 of the Indian Constitution, which had granted limited autonomy to the state of Jammu and Kashmir. The subsequent decision to divide the state into two Union Territories – J&K and Ladakh – must have come as a rude shock to Pakistani authorities. As a result, the ISI is expected to further bolster its pro-Khalistan propaganda in Punjab and in countries such as Canada, the UK and the US, which have a sizeable Sikh diaspora.

Over the years, Pakistan's ISI has created a number of organizations, assets, and built an impressive infrastructure within Pakistan, in Western countries and even among some sympathisers in Punjab to carry forward its anti-India and pro-Khalistan agenda. Out of the nine foreign-based Sikhs declared as individual terrorists under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA) by the Ministry of Home Affairs on 1 July 2020, four enjoy the ISI's hospitality in Pakistan. They are Paramjit Singh Panjwar, head of Khalistan Commando Force (KCF), Ranjit Singh Neeta, head of